The boss understands soccer like very few other people. That means whatever situation the team's in, either during a season or during a game, the players have the feeling he knows exactly what to do. He's aware that he's got the power to change things and he's never afraid of doing that, even when the best thing to do is nothing, whatever anybody else might be saying. I think everyone's heard enough about 'The Hairdryer'. It's been talked about so often, you might imagine that's what life is like in the United dressing room all the time. It isn't. What people outside Old Trafford should understand is what everyone inside the club already knows: whatever the manager does is what he thinks is right for the team at a particular time.

I remember an amazing game, the week before England played Greece in 2001, down at White Hart Lane. I was so hyped up for the afternoon. I was captain of the United first team for the very first time. The way the manager let me know was typical: he just dropped the players' match tickets into my lap before dinner at the team hotel the night before. Handing those tickets round was the captain's job. I didn't even have time to turn around and start getting emotional: the boss was already away down at the other end of the room. I was so proud, especially as I knew Grandad, who still followed Spurs, would be there with Mum and Dad.

Being captain would have been enough on its own to make the afternoon stick in my memory. And I still remember it for that. I bet nobody else does. Too much else happened besides. At half-time, we'd had it: Tottenham were winning 3–0, hammering us. You'd expect a manager, when his team's played that badly, to try and shake up his players. That afternoon, the boss came into the dressing room and was completely calm about the situation. There were no recriminations. There were no angry words. I sat on the floor, thinking the game was as good as over. I looked around and I could see the other lads, heads down, feeling the same way. The boss just walked in and perched himself on a bench. He didn't say much beyond:

'Let's keep the score down now.'

But he knew his players well enough, and trusted us enough, to let us react for ourselves, in the way he expected we would. I'm sure I wasn't the only player who suddenly found himself thinking: *I'm not going to lose to Spurs like this*.

We went out for the second half, Andy Cole scored early on and we turned it around. We beat them 5–3. It was one of the most amazing 45 minutes of soccer in which I've ever been involved. And it had been really